the Jan Sangh' and the forces of progress. He framed communalism as the 'foremost question'[18] before the country in that election, at a time when the Jan Sangh had been born only four days before voting started, the Hindu Mahasabha had only recently turned into a political party and the RSS was not contesting elections. The major Opposition parties of the time were not Hindu nationalist; they were socialist. The Jan Sangh only won 3 per cent of the votes in 1952, the Socialist Party 10.5 per cent and the Kisan Mazdoor Praja Party 5.7 per cent.

Within these pages, I reconstruct the politics of independent India's first election in 1951-52 to show that Nehru defined his position in this manner not necessarily because he thought that the Jan Sangh was politically strong—it was not—but because the ideals it represented enjoyed deep support within the Congress leadership itself, specifically on the question of the Hindus who still remained in Pakistan and the Nehru government's policies towards them. After Jan Sangh founder Syama Prasad Mookerjee's exit from the Nehru cabinet to form his own party, the objections he raised to Nehru's policies on Hindu cultural grounds[19] enjoyed such support within the Hindu-traditionalist wing of the Congress that it led to the most serious internal challenge that Nehru faced to his own leadership until the Sino-Indian War of 1962.[20]

This challenge was exemplified by the stunning election of Congress's UP chief Purshottamdas Tandon as Congress president on 2 September 1950, when he defeated Acharya Kriplani, whom Nehru supported. Not since Mahatma Gandhi took on Subhas Chandra Bose after his victory as Congress president at the Congress's 1939 Tripuri session had the party seen such a schism at the top. Tandon's elevation was specifically seen at the time as a signal from the Congress to Nehru for a 'reorientation of policy', especially on 'India–Pakistan relations', 'refugees' and 'propagation of Hindi'.[21] Nehru responded by asking his party for a renewed mandate on his Pakistan policies and the 'communal question' in a specially convened Nasik session of the All India Congress Committee (AICC) on 21–22 September 1950. At that session, in a masterful speech delivered at a rain-soaked ground full of slush, the prime minister threatened to resign if his policies were not endorsed.